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cover story GLOBAL WARMING

Bore Well?

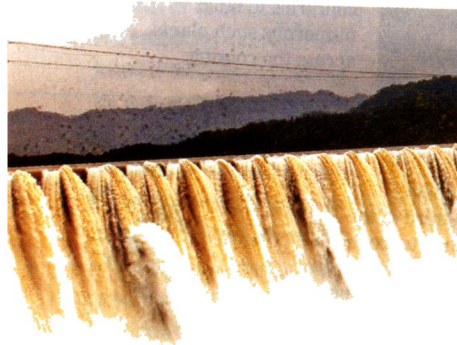
Not really. Borewells that form the major source of India's water supply are now beginning to run dry. The dig for them is getting even deeper and costlier. Groundwater accounts for nearly 40 per cent of the available water resources, meeting 85 per cent of the rural requirement and 50 per cent of urban and industrial needs. But most states are experiencing an alarming fall in water table as groundwater is being over-exploited. There is need for mandated water harvesting and recharge zones in urban areas. There is also need to recharge deep aquifers and prevent their over-use. There could even be a regulation on power tariffs for irrigation.

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Breezy Stuff

In terms of renewable energy, few can beat the wind, except of course, the sun. Wind power has been growing in India which now stands at around 8,000 MW, making the country the fourth largest producer in the world. Suzlon, an Indian company, is estimated to control 10.5 per cent of the world market. There is still plenty of potential to exploit. If you have a farm in the outback or are living in an area with erratic power supply, it might help to have a windmill in your backyard.

AP/WIDE WORLD



Stop the Run-off

India gets an average of 600 mm of rainfall a year. This means a total precipitation of 4,000 billion metric tonne—a mini sea of water deluging us every year. Yet, as much of 75 per cent of this is lost due to run-offs. As a result many parts of the country are water-stressed and are in danger of turning into water-scarce regions in the next 30 years. That may sound far off but the interim could be harsh with daily battles over water. There is an urgent need to improve water harvesting systems and put the deluge to more productive use. If necessary, even build dams for storage.

Hit the Ceiling

The humble ceiling fan that adorns most homes is now the subject of intensive research. Given that there must be close to 300 million of them and in India's hot and humid conditions, these usually work overtime. But as experts are discovering, many of them are not all that energy efficient, adding many-a-tonne to India's GUG emissions. Now, fan manufacturers are offering far more efficient energy savers as substitutes for those old overheaders.

Home Audits

So you thought you had a green home? Best to get a home energy audit done by experts who tell you just where you can save your power, how efficient your air-conditioners are, what alternatives should you use, including appliances available in the market that are more energy efficient. Internet site offer to guide you free of charge in case you don't want to fork out money.

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Bright Lights

You see them on neon lights, illuminating signboards with dazzling colours. Now, they just may begin to start replacing CFLs. So far, the high cost and the low luminosity didn't make Light Emitting Diodes or LEDs, better substitutes for fluorescent or incandescent bulbs. But new developments have made them viable and soon they will be coming to a store near you.

